



PHOTO BY HARDIK CHHABRA

FOCUS ON INVESTORS Deepak Bagla, MD & CEO of Invest India, says investors prefer a plug-and-play model

leadership. And this is what Invest India personifies. We are working with state governments, showing them global best practices, then rating Indian global best practices vis-à-vis theirs, and then training them to come up the curve on those. We have also started partnering the states that are doing better with the ones that are weaker.

The other interesting element is how state governments are upgrading their industrial parks to make India a plug-and-play model. This is very important, especially for the movement of MSMEs. If I have a big mobile maker coming in, you want the entire supply chain. The supply chain is MSMEs. The first thing they want is complete facilitation, hand-holding, which is what Invest India does—from location search to showing them the opportunity to getting all approvals.

The second, which is more important for them, is that they need an ecosystem within which they can work and do a plug-and-play model. That is what we are seeing developing very fast in India.

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What kind of work is Invest India doing in the start-up space?

The first challenge

was to create the ecosystem. Second, how do we respect failure? That was a social challenge. We work with each state government on its specific start-up policy, creating the ecosystem, creating the incentives, taking best-case examples from one and sharing with the other. The next step is to see how we can bring all the start-ups together and help them by joining the dots. So, we created the Startup India Hub, which is like a virtual incubator. In that virtual incubator, you get

everything from learning how to ideate, to creating a presentation, to meeting a VC, to finding a mentor, to getting an incubator, and to getting a market. Hand-holding happens [through the] entire chain.

We also have the Prime Minister's science and technology initiative. There are two elements to it—one is waste to wealth. We are bringing in new technologies on waste to wealth. For example, we are trying to see how the Ghazipur dump (in Delhi) can be converted into a road.

The other element is that we are bringing in the best innovations from outside the government into the government, be it agriculture, defence, etc.

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How are you engaging with the domestic, large industrial houses or even the large to medium industrial houses, which also need some hand-holding?

Of the ₹2.4 lakh crore investment that we have already brought in, close to about ₹18,000-20,000 crore is domestic investment. We have created a project management group for big companies. This used to be earlier under the Cabinet Secretariat. Even the large private projects can come in. And these are being monitored at the highest level. So, in their daily meetings with either the chief secretary or the chief minister's office of

that state, or senior government officials from India, [they are asked] where is it stuck? What more can we do? We go state by state. And we have already sorted out a large number of these issues. But the big change is [that] we have made it far more vibrant.

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Does WAIPA help in getting FDI?

The World Bank

advises all governments on investment promotion. And they were with us from Day One. They actually created a case study on Invest India last October, which they have shared with governments across the globe to tell them how they can structure an IPA, and how a country's leadership can create an institution of global excellence in a short period of time. So, how WAIPA helps us is it creates awareness across the world, that [India] is the place which is now really open to investment. The other very interesting thing for me is, when we are looking at India, two-thirds of my GDP is driven by domestic demand. So, you come, you create here, you create economies of scale. And then you export. For me, it is important to open other markets for these companies, so they can export from here. That's where WAIPA comes in. **BT**

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